

CIGGIES—SUCKERS—SANITY

"Been following all this rowdy-dow about cigarets and lung cancer," said our friend Porfirio P. Punctilio the other evening, "with no little interest.

"You're familiar with the latest development, of course, if development it can be justly called.



Dr. E. Cuyler Hammond

"The American Cancer Society maps out a five-year research project on whether cigarets have any connection with lung cancer.

"Two and a half years go by, and then the guy who's directing the job—Dr. E. Cuyler Hammond of Yale, if I ain't mistaken, and I ain't—jumps the gun and releases a mess of what he calls preliminary findings to the papers.

"The papers print the stuff prominently, which again makes liars out of people who keep saying the papers are afraid of their advertisers. Cigaret makers, of course, are among the papers' biggest and juiciest advertisers.

"Dr. Hammond allows as how the dope he's collected up to now shows such high death rates among male cigaret smokers 50 to 70 years old that he didn't think he could properly wait any longer to buzz the general public.

"The research isn't finished as planned, or anywhere near it. There's so much hedging and double-talk in Hammond's alleged findings, as reported in the papers, that I defy anybody to discover just what the good doctor does or doesn't think about cigarets and lung cancer.

"But a hazy impression gets around once more that cigarets are likely to cause this dreaded disease, and a few suckers—as I call 'em, anyway—switch to some other method of absorbing nicotine, and some tobacco stocks wobble noticeably on the big board."

"Well," continued P. P. Punctilio, after lighting a fresh king-size cigaret from the glowing stub of a previous one, "I don't know whether cigarets cause lung cancer, or liquor causes cirrhosis, or candy causes diabetes, or playing tennis causes heart trouble.

"Furthermore, I don't give a hoot. I like cigarets, liquor, candy and exercise. I also love the life I lead—largely because I take all the things I like whenever I want 'em, and refuse to worry about whether they're doing me harm or good or having no effect on me at all.

The King Statistic "I operate this way because I know I've got only one life to live in this mortal world, and am going to die some day of something or other. All these statistics—how four out of 10 die of this and two out of 50 die of that—hell, man, the king statistic of 'em all is that one out of one dies eventually.

"So why not enjoy life while you've got it, and do what you can to help other people enjoy life—make the best and happiest use you can of the physical and mental machine the Good Lord gave you—and leave the worrying lay?"

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"And speaking of worry about health," Punc' went on, through a cloud of gray exhaled cigaret smoke, "I think some of our esteemed doctors have a good deal to answer for on that score.

"The ones, I mean, who keep yelling in print or on the air about how you've got to worry over every kind of disease, check your symptoms every hour on the hour, and so on. The cancer folks have been especially eager-beaver for upwards of 25 years.

'A Nation Of Hypos? "What these scare campaigns might do is turn us into a nation of hypochondriacs eventually—you know, people who enjoy poor health—though I think most Americans are too smart for that. But the danger is there, just the same; and if we should turn into 160,000,000 hypos, we'd soon be bidding a long farewell to all our glory as a nation and a people.

"Sure, I'm for public health education—but in a positive, cheerful way, like that Dr. Van Dellen who writes those medical pieces for THE NEWS—not morbid stuff that'll more likely than not turn a well person sick.

"And I'm convinced, too, that some of the cigaret people brought some of this present unpleasantness on themselves, by letting on that their cigarets were better for you than other cigarets. That must have started a few people, anyway, to thinking that maybe all cigarets were dangerous.

"Well," concluded Porfy Punctilio, "don't take this as a market tip, son; but as soon as certain high-class tobacco stocks have fallen as far as I think they're going to fall because of this passing scare, I'm intending to buy some."

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